28 October 2026

English only

Human Rights Council
Sixty-fifth session

Sudan's unrelenting war: civilian devastation and deepening insecurity in El Obeid

Independent international fact-finding mission for the Sudan

Summary

The independent international fact-finding mission for the Sudan finds that the threat to civilians in El Obeid has changed but remains acute. Although the complete siege and large-scale ground assault feared in June 2026 did not materialise during the reporting period, shifting front lines and the reopening of some corridors have not secured civilian safety. Continued drone attacks and insecurity including along supply routes expose civilians to further violence and deprivation, while surveillance and arbitrary detention obstruct their ability to report violations and seek protection.

The Rapid Support Forces' campaign of long-range drone attacks continues to kill and injure civilians, destroy civilian infrastructure and compound displacement pressures. Although the Sudanese Armed Forces have maintained control of the reopened Khartoum–El-Obeid corridor, sustained drone attacks along the route continue to impede civilian movement. Damage to essential infrastructure further disrupts access to water, healthcare and other basic services extending the consequences of attacks beyond their immediate sites of impact.

The deployment of Sudanese Armed Forces personnel and military vehicles in residential neighbourhoods, near civilian homes, markets and other populated areas, has exposed civilians to attacks. The proximity of military objectives does not diminish the obligations under international humanitarian law to protect civilians or relieve either party of these obligations.

Alongside these threats, civic space in El Obeid is shrinking. Security actors affiliated with the Sudanese Armed Forces have intensified surveillance, with individuals targeted for their engagement in peace initiatives, humanitarian activities and human rights work. The mission finds that reprisals, arbitrary arrest and detention, ill-treatment and torture foster fear and deter civilians from reporting violations, seeking protection and cooperating with accountability efforts, weakening protection and obstructing the prospects for justice.

I. Introduction

1. This conference room paper focuses on the situation in El Obeid, North Kordofan. It presents the findings of the independent international fact-finding mission for the Sudan ("the mission") concerning three interrelated areas: the continuing threats to civilians in and around El Obeid; expanding hostilities elsewhere in Sudan including in Blue Nile State, and their implications for civilian protection and regional stability; and patterns of arbitrary arrest and detention, torture, and reprisals that are shrinking civic space in El Obeid. The mission shared these findings with the Sudan on 26 October 2026. No response was received by the time of publication.

2. In making its findings, the mission assessed all information in accordance with its standard of proof, namely whether there were reasonable grounds to believe that an incident occurred as described and that the findings reached were supported by a sufficient body of credible and corroborated information.

II. The situation in and around El Obeid

3. On 3 July 2026, the Human Rights Council held an urgent debate on the human rights situation in and around El Obeid, North Kordofan.[1] Consequently, on 6 July, the Council adopted resolution 62/1, without a vote, requesting the mission to conduct "an urgent inquiry into any violations and abuses of international human rights law and violations of international humanitarian law and related international crimes, allegedly committed in and around El Obeid in the context of the ongoing conflict in the Sudan".[2] The Council further encouraged the mission to update it on the outcome of the inquiry during the interactive dialogue at the Council's sixty-third session and to update the General Assembly during the interactive dialogue at the Assembly's eighty-first session.

4. In conducting the inquiry, the mission interviewed 29 individuals with direct knowledge of developments in and around El Obeid, including residents of the city and consulted other relevant stakeholders. The mission also drew on expert consultations it held in Nairobi, Kenya on 5 June 2026 and in London, the United Kingdom on 17, 18 and 19 August 2026.

5. The mission examined satellite imagery, photographs, videos, documentary evidence and other open-source material. This material was subjected to verification and corroboration through witness and victim testimony, geolocation, satellite imagery, expert analysis and other independent sources.

6. The mission remains concerned about the deteriorating protection environment for victims, witnesses and others perceived as cooperating with documentation and accountability efforts, a pattern previously documented across Sudan. In El Obeid, witnesses expressed fears of surveillance, detention and reprisals, reporting that communications were monitored by security actors and that civilians, including women and children, had been arrested on suspicion of collaborating with the Rapid Support Forces. Persistent telecommunication disruptions further complicated reaching out to residents, while fears that contact with investigators could expose individuals or their families to retaliation discouraged some residents from reporting violations.

[1] https://www.ohchr.org/en/press-releases/2026/06/sudan-human-rights-council-hold-urgent-debate-3-july-human-rights-situation.

[2] Human Rights Council resolution 62/1, Human rights situation in and around El Obeid, in the context of the ongoing conflict in the Sudan, A/HRC/RES/62/1, adopted 6 July 2026, para. 17.

A. Evolving military operations in and around El Obeid

7. El Obeid, the capital of North Kordofan, remained a critical civilian, administrative and humanitarian hub linking central Sudan with Darfur and South Kordofan. Its strategic position along major transport routes, with a railway terminus and airport, underpinned its longstanding importance as a trading centre for gum arabic, millet, oilseeds and livestock. It is home to more than half a million residents and over 100,000 internally displaced persons, alongside many others sheltering with host families or in informal sites, including many whom fled El Fasher and other cities devastated by the conflict.

8. As headquarters of the Sudanese Armed Forces' Fifth Infantry Division, it is also a strategic military and logistical centre. Control of the city, and its approaches, is central to the contest between the Sudanese Armed Forces and the Rapid Support Forces for territory and supply routes across Kordofan. Although the city remained under Sudanese Armed Forces' control, Rapid Support Forces positions along key approaches restricted movement and supplies. Military pressure intensified in June 2026, with repeated drone attacks affecting military positions, populated areas and infrastructure essential to civilian life, amid growing concern over a possible large scale ground offensive.[3]

9. The military situation shifted in late July, when the Sudanese Armed Forces and allied forces recaptured Bara, Jabrat al-Sheikh and other positions along the northern corridor, reopening the main road connecting El Obeid with Khartoum and breaking the Rapid Support Forces encirclement. Further advances in September and early October extended Sudanese Armed Forces' and their allied forces' control westwards and north-westwards, including reported advances around Kajmar and Sharshar, the recapture of Sodari on 25 September and the reported capture of Al-Mazroub on 2 October. These operations weakened the Rapid Support Forces positions in North Kordofan and strengthened the Sudanese Armed Forces control over strategic routes, although fighting and insecurity persisted in surrounding areas.[4]

10. The changing frontlines did not remove the threat to El Obeid. Drone attacks attributed to the Rapid Support Forces continued to reach the city held by the Sudanese Armed Forces, including strikes affecting educational facilities and populated areas in September and October. Though the reopening of key routes reduced the city's physical isolation, continued aerial attacks, insecurity and disruption of essential services remained significant threats to civilians.

11. These developments occurred as civilians displaced from across Kordofan and Darfur continued to arrive in El Obeid. The growing displaced population, combined with continued aerial attacks and destruction of civilian infrastructure, heightened civilian exposure to violence and disruption of essential services despite the changing military situation.

B. Recruitment, mobilization and allied forces

12. Individuals interviewed by the mission described sustained recruitment and mobilization efforts by the Sudanese Armed Forces, the Joint Forces and affiliated groups in El Obeid, including the Al-Baraa Ibn Malik Brigade. Recruitment campaigns reportedly targeted young men through public messaging and

[3] FFMS-D-005698; FFMS-D-005697; FFMS-D-005699.

[4] https://dppa.un.org/en/node/136540? Sudan and South Sudan - Security Council, 10211th meeting 24 August. UN Security Council briefing, 24 August 2026 https://transcripts.un.org/en/sc/10211?.

mobilization camps. Lack of economic opportunity and fear of being branded disloyal to the army were among the reasons cited for joining the groups.[5]

13. Witnesses also described the presence of Sudanese Armed Forces and Joint Forces personnel and armed civilian auxiliaries known as "mobilized" or “mustanfireen” (public resistance groups) in El Obeid. El Obeid became a highly militarised city as a result.[6]

C. Drone strikes and the conduct of hostilities in densely populated areas

14. In its September 2026 report, *Fuelling the conflict in the Sudan: weapons, fighters and external support networks*, (A/HRC/63/23), the mission documented how expanded drone capabilities had extended the reach of hostilities beyond immediate frontlines, exposing civilians and civilian infrastructure to attacks across Sudan.

15. Drone attacks on El Obeid intensified sharply in June 2026. Although their frequency subsequently fluctuated, further strikes affected the city in September and October despite shifts in the surrounding front lines. Attacks continued to affect populated areas, including residential neighbourhoods, educational facilities and locations where civilians gathered or sought shelter, leaving civilians exposed to the threat of aerial attack even in places where they sought safety.[7]

16. The proximity of military personnel and objectives to civilian homes and facilities was a recurring concern. Sudanese Armed Forces and allied personnel reportedly occupied rented houses and other residential buildings, with deployment in residential neighbourhoods near civilian homes, markets and other populated areas. Witnesses described repeatedly moving between homes amid recurrent drone strikes, fearing that the presence of military personnel in residential neighbourhoods increased the risk of civilian casualties and damage to surrounding properties.[8]

17. During June, attacks by the Rapid Support Forces reportedly struck fuel stations, the Sudanese Armed Forces 5th Infantry Division headquarters and surrounding areas, and the city's electricity infrastructure. Witnesses also described successive strikes on residential properties, including in Al-Muwazzafeen, Al-Amir and Al-Matar neighbourhoods. This included drone strikes affecting residential neighbourhoods where Sudanese Armed Forces and allied personnel were reportedly accommodated in civilian properties or operated in close proximity to civilian homes causing civilian deaths, injuries and damage to homes.[9]

18. The risks to civilians were illustrated by drone strikes affecting residential properties in Al-Muwazzafeen neighbourhood on 10 and 11 June 2026.[10] A witness reported that a drone strike destroyed his sister's home and killed at least three civilians in a neighbouring property.[11] The witness stated that members of the Al-Baraa Ibn Malik Brigade were staying in a nearby house. Other accounts described drone attacks and civilian deaths in Al-Jawhara and Al-Matar, where military

[5] FFMS-D-005698; FFMS-D-005699.
[6] FFMS-D-005698; FFMS-D-005699; FFMS-D-5696; FFMS-D-5693.
[7] FFMS-D-005698; FFMS-D-005673; FFMS-D-005677; FFMS-D-005674; FFMS-D-005640; FFMS-D-005675; 5676.
[8] FFMS-D-005640; FFMS-D-005689; FFMS-D-005640; FFMS-D-005682; FFMS-D-005677; FFMS-D-005630; FFMS-D-005682; FFMS-D-005673; FFMS-D-005688; FFMS-D-005672; FFMS-D-005692; FFMS-D-005697; FFMS-D-005687; FFMS-D-00 5672.
[9] FFMS_0479; FFMS-D-005685; FFMS-D-005649; FFMS-D-005673; FFMS-D-005675; FFMS-D-005692; FFMS-D-005678.
[10] FFMS_0480; FFMS-D-005673.
[11] FFMS_0479; FFMS_0480; FFMS-D-005673.

personnel were reportedly staying in residential properties.[12] In a separate incident on 9 June, another witness recounted fleeing with his family following a strike on a house believed to be occupied by Sudanese Armed Forces personnel, approximately 90 meters from his home. A subsequent strike on the same property a short time after damaged neighbouring buildings.

19. Strikes on military vehicles moving through populated areas also took place, including a drone attack in Al-Salihin neighbourhood that reportedly killed civilians alongside military personnel and attacks near schools that caused child casualties, as previously documented by the mission.[13] Several witnesses described successive strikes on locations where people had gathered following earlier attacks, including incidents in which civilians approaching to assist the injured were reportedly killed or wounded. In one incident, a witness described a drone attack during a funeral for victims of an earlier drone attack.[14]

20. Drone attacks continued to affect El Obeid and surrounding areas throughout September and into October 2026. On 9 September, a strike damaged the College of Developmental and Technological Sciences, reportedly killing a security guard.[15] Further strikes reported in September affected residential neighbourhoods, a displacement shelter and other civilian locations, causing deaths and injuries. On 20 September, drone strikes on two warehouses in Shikan locality destroyed more than 330,000 educational materials intended for distribution at the start of the school year.[16] A further strike was reported on or around 28 September in the Sheikan College and Sports City area.[17] On 30 September, a strike on the Al Mina Al Bari displacement site reportedly killed one child and injured 12 others,[18] while a further strike reported on 1 October at a University of Kordofan dormitory reportedly killed five civilians and injured 47.

21. Taken together, these accounts raise serious concerns regarding the grave risks to civilians from attacks in populated areas. The proximity of military personnel and objectives to civilian homes and facilities heightened the foreseeable risk of civilian harm from drone strikes, including from blast, fragmentation and damage to neighbouring structures. These risks were especially significant where recurrent attacks and insecurity limited civilians' practical means of avoiding attacks. The mission reiterates that the presence of military objectives in populated areas does not diminish the protection afforded to civilians or relieve attacking parties of their obligations of distinction, proportionality and precautions in attack. The deployment of the Sudanese Armed Forces and allied personnel also engages their obligation to take all feasible precautions to protect civilians under their control from the effects of attacks and, to the extent feasible, avoid locating military objectives in or near densely populated areas. Recurrent strikes, limited opportunities to shelter or evacuate, and earlier disruptions to essential services are further relevant to assessing foreseeable civilian harm and the effectiveness of warnings and other precautions in subsequent attacks.

22. The mission also received reports of deteriorating security conditions in areas surrounding El Obeid and across North Kordofan, where shifting front lines, Rapid Support Forces' deployment and contested territorial control exposed civilians to killings, other abuses and displacement. Civilians faced overlapping threats from

[12] FFMS_0479; FFMS-D-005688; FFMS-D-005640; FFMS-D-005673; FFMS-D-00565678.
[13] A/HRC/63/23.
[14] FFMS-D-005687; FFMS-D-005677; FFMS-D-005640; FFMS-D-005676.
[15] FFMS_0480; FFMS_0479.
[16] https://www.unicef.org/press-releases/drone-strikes-destroy-more-330000-learning-materials-sudans-north-kordofan-state?.
[17] FFMS_0480.
[18] https://www.unicef.org/sudan/press-releases/13-children-reportedly-killed-or-injured-drone-strike-displacement-shelter-al-obeid?.

ground operations and persistent drone attacks, with insecurity extending well beyond the city itself. The risks were particularly acute where territorial control changed.

a) Civilian consequences

23. As previously documented by the mission, drone attacks aggravated already severe humanitarian conditions in El Obeid, where prolonged isolation, disrupted supply routes and displacement had placed essential services under extreme pressure.[19] Damage to electricity and fuel infrastructure disrupted water supplies and critical hospital services, including surgery, oxygen provision and dialysis. Amid shortages of blood and medical supplies, these disruptions further constrained the capacity to treat casualties with severe blast and fragmentation injuries, including among children, which can involve major haemorrhage, internal organ damage and traumatic amputation[20]. The danger is compounded when the same pattern of drone strikes that produces complex trauma also damages or disables the services required to treat it leaving survivors without the care needed to stay alive. The mission notes that the full extent of this harm is difficult to assess without full access to Sudan.

24. The consequences extend beyond the immediate casualties of individual strikes. Witnesses described profound distress at seeing dismembered bodies, persistent fear of further strikes, disturbed sleep, and repeated relocation between homes, often with few or no safe alternatives. One witness reported that children had become familiar with distinguishing between “suicide” and “strategic” drones because of their frequent use.[21] Fear also affected daily activities, discouraging movement to markets, schools and water points. The mission notes that these interconnected effects deepened existing deprivation, affecting civilians' sense of safety, freedom of movement and ability to maintain daily life, including within their own homes.

b) Impact of drone strikes on women and children

25. Evidence collected by the mission indicates that drone attacks contributed to further insecurity and the repeated displacement among women and children, including those previously displaced from El Fasher, Kadugli, Bara, Dilling, and the areas surrounding El Obeid. Humanitarian and medical sources reported that a substantial number of displaced persons were women, particularly widows, and children, including unaccompanied children. One service provider estimated that women supported approximately 90% of households she assisted. These accounts indicate the disproportionate burden of displacement on women and illustrate the growing responsibility borne by displaced women for supporting their families amid the loss of livelihoods and support from family and community.

26. Depleted resources and limited livelihood opportunities left women unable to flee again despite continuing drone attacks and growing insecurity.[22] One witness said that women *“went door to door seeking domestic work [...] but there were very few livelihood opportunities available*”.[23] Other witnesses reported that some displaced women could not afford sanitary products and resorted to reusing cloths without adequate facilities or water for washing and maintaining hygiene, increasing the risk of infection.[24] The combined effects of displacement, insecurity and diminished resources further restricted women's capacity to meet their own essential needs while providing for their families.

[19] FFMS-D-005697; FFMS-D-005698; FFMS-D-005699; FFMS-D-005687; FFMS-D-005672; FFMS-D-005673; FFMS-D-005685.
[20] FFMS-D-005673; FFMS-D-005685; FFMS-D-005681; FFMS-D-005689; FFMS-D-005674; FFMS-D-005640; FFMS-D-005693; FFMS-D-005696.
[21] FFMS-D-005689; FFMS-D-005678; FFMS-D-005640; FFMS-D-005688.
[22] FFMS-D-005687.
[23] FFMS-D-005679; FFMS-D-005676.
[24] FFMS-D-005676; FFMS-D-005687.

27. Women face a stark choice: remain amid recurrent aerial attacks and risks of sexual and gender-based violence, including alleged abuses by the Joint Forces, or flee again without adequate resources or safe means of travel. For those unable to leave, overcrowded displacement sites, inadequate shelter and unsafe water and sanitation facilities heightened their exposure to harassment, sexual violence and exploitation. Although the scale of such abuses cannot be established at present, these conditions increased the risks faced by women and girls while limiting their opportunities to seek safety and protection. Even obtaining basic necessities carried additional risks.

28. Accounts received by the mission illustrate that drone attacks affecting water sources and distribution points during daylight hours led women and girls to collect water after dark, exposing them to harassment and sexual violence.[25] The mission also received accounts of sexual exploitation and coercion linked to control of scarce water resources.[26] The threat of drone attacks thus further constrained women's options for safety while increasing their exposure to other forms of harm including sexual violence, in the course of meeting essential daily needs.

29. These risks were further aggravated by the disruption of healthcare and protection services. Attacks affecting health facilities and essential infrastructure constrained the availability of sexual and reproductive healthcare and services for survivors of gender-based violence, including timely access to emergency contraception, post-exposure prophylaxis, treatment of injuries and psychosocial support.[27] For women already facing restricted movement and limited means of leaving, these disruptions further reduced access to essential assistance and protection.

30. Drone attacks on civilian infrastructure and health facilities have had direct and indirect effects on pregnant women and children. Medical personnel reported that repeated drone attacks on fuel facilities, electricity, water services, and hospitals severely disrupted health care in El Obeid. One expert estimated that after the attacks on the hospitals, only about 30% of them remained operational in El Obeid.[28] Power shortages affected the maternity hospital: women who needed emergency obstetric surgery faced outages and equipment shortages.[29] On 16 June 2026, a nearby drone strike damaged the maternity hospital's operating rooms and pharmacy, suspending operations. Medical personnel also described births taking place amid severe shortages of medicines, supplements, qualified personnel and specialist care, with some women giving birth without medical assistance.[30] Such disruptions are particularly serious in obstetric emergencies, including severe haemorrhage and obstructed labour, where delays in obtaining blood transfusions or emergency surgery can be fatal.

31. Children were among those killed and injured in attacks in populated civilian areas, including locations near schools, while damage to civilian infrastructure further undermined services essential to their survival and development. According to UNICEF, more than 400 children were reportedly killed or injured across Sudan between January and September 2026, with drone attacks accounting for a significant

[25] https://unwomen.org.au/un-women-statement-drone-attacks-by-day-and-sexual-violence-by-night-leave-no-safe-window-for-women-and-girls-to-collect-water-amidst-rainy-season-in-sudans-el-obeid/?.

[26] FFMS-D-005679.

[27] https://www.unfpa.org/resources/flash-update-situation-el-obeid-north-kordofan-sudan-2-july-2026; https://www.unfpa.org/resources/unfpa-situation-report-sudan-%E2%80%93-march-2026?page=3&utm.

[28] FFMS-D-005678.

[29] FFMS-D-005687.

[30] FFMS-D-005687; FFMS-D-005676.

proportion of these casualties.[31] The mission received multiple accounts of drone strikes in El Obeid occurring near schools, including as previously reported a drone strike near Dar al Fikr school in June which caused the death of one schoolgirl and injured several others.[32] The attack reportedly targeted a fuel tanker beside the school.[33]

32. Casualty figures capture only part of the harm. Drone attacks and the continuing threat of further attacks disrupted children's access to education, health care, clean water and safe shelter.[34] Schools closed for prolonged periods, with some used as shelter for internally displaced people.[35] Repeated displacement and interrupted schooling further constrained educational opportunities, including for girls already facing heightened protection risks which may increase their exposure to other forms of exploitation and gender-based harm, including child marriage.[36]

D. Expanding frontlines

33. The conflict in Sudan continues to intensify and spread, with neither party having secured a decisive military advantage. The extension of hostilities towards international borders has increased civilian exposure to violence and displacement with risks extending into neighbouring countries.

34. In the south-east, Blue Nile state, bordering South Sudan and Ethiopia, has emerged as a secondary theatre of war aimed at halting the Sudanese Armed Forces advances in the Kordofan region. Since early 2026, territorial control in and around Kurmuk and Geissan, two strategic towns on the southeastern border has repeatedly shifted between the parties to the conflict. Ground offensives coupled with increasing drone operations have again exposed civilians to hostilities, displacing many towards the capital Al-Damazine and neighbouring areas.

35. The mission has also received reports of drone strikes by the Rapid Support Forces near a displacement camp in Wad al-Mahi locality reportedly killing at least 30 displaced people, including women and children, and wounding dozens of others,[37] and at a health centre in Um Darfa reportedly killing a Sudanese Red Crescent volunteer,[38] both occurring in Blue Nile state in the first two weeks of October.

36. The mission has also received reports of renewed ground fighting between the Sudanese Armed Forces and the Sudan People's Liberation Movement-North al-Hilu, allied with the Rapid Support Forces, near Kurmuk on 19 October and Sally on 20 October respectively. The preceding months of hostilities reportedly caused further

[31] UNICEF, 13 children reportedly killed or injured in drone strike on displacement shelter in Al Obeid, Sudan, 1 October 2026, paragraph 3. https://www.unicef.org/sudan/press-releases/13-children-reportedly-killed-or-injured-drone-strike-displacement-shelter-al-obeid.

[32] A/HRC/63/23; FFMS-D-005674; FFMS-D-005676; FFMS-D-005688; FFMS-D-005689.

[33] FFMS-D-005677; FFMS-D-005678; FFMS-D-005674.

[34] FFMS_0481; FFMS-D-005687; FFMS-D-005630; FFMS-D-005677; FFMS-D-005674; FFMS-D-005676; FFMS-D-005689.

[35] FFMS-D-005686; FFMS-D-005501, FFMS-D-005490, FFMS-D-005489, FFMS-D-005520, FFMS-D-005513.

[36] FFMS-D-005518.

[37] https://reliefweb.int/report/sudan/statement-united-nations-resident-and-humanitarian-coordinator-sudan-denise-brown?; Https://africa.unwomen.org/en/stories/statement/2026/10/majority-of-people-killed-in-sudans-drone-attack-on-a-displacement-site-in-blue-nile-state-are-women-and-children.

[38] Https://news.un.org/en/story/2026/10/1168628.

displacement and damage to civilian infrastructure, including Kurmuk Hospital.[39] These developments reflect continued shifts in territorial control. Continued ground fighting and drone strikes, including incidents affecting civilian areas heighten the risk of further civilian casualties and displacement while threatening escape routes and placing additional pressure on receiving communities.

37. Further northwest, in Um Badr, North Kordofan, approximately 270 kilometres from El Obeid, the mission verified footage reportedly recorded on 24 September showing the execution of approximately 25 persons accused of looting Um Badr market. The blindfolded victims, whose hands were bound, appeared to have been executed while in the custody or under the control of members of the Rapid Support Forces. The summary execution of persons in custody is prohibited under common Article 3 of the Geneva Conventions, and where the requisite elements are established, amounts to a war crime.

38. Two deadly attacks took place while this report was being drafted. On 10 October 2026, it was reported that Egyptian airstrikes attacked artisanal gold mining sites at Jabal al-Uqaydat in the Shamal al-Wadi area near a disputed border between Sudan and Egypt, killing at least 72 artisanal gold miners at the time of reporting and injuring dozens more. The mission continues to investigate the circumstances of the attacks and those responsible.

39. The mission is also investigating a drone attack on 19 October, reportedly by the Sudanese Armed Forces, on a market in Abyei, a disputed area between Sudan and South Sudan killing at least 80 persons and injuring 27 others.[40]

E. Humanitarian conditions and civilian protection

40. The humanitarian situation in El Obeid remained critical despite changes in territorial control and the partial reopening of some supply routes. Continued arrivals of civilians displaced by fighting across Kordofan placed further pressure on essential services already weakened by prolonged insecurity and hostilities.[41] Shelter and basic services struggled to absorb the arrivals. Displaced families faced overcrowded conditions in camps and informal settlements, while others sought shelter with host families, frequently in conditions of inadequate access to water and sanitation, food and other basic services.[42] The growing demands further strained host communities, already struggling to meet their own essential needs.[43]

a) Essential services and civilian infrastructure

41. The effects of earlier damage to electricity, water and fuel infrastructure persisted, compounded by fuel shortages, insecurity along supply routes and increased demand. Access to safe drinking water remained severely constrained, with witnesses reporting prolonged queues, high costs and reliance on unsafe sources.[44] Overcrowding and inadequate sanitation further increased the risk of waterborne

[39] FFMS_0483; https://www.unicef.org/sudan/press-releases/attacks-against-hospitals-and-health-facilities-must-end?

[40] Secretary-General Condemns Drone Attacks in Abyei | UN Meetings Coverage and Press Releases.

[41] https://dtm.iom.int/reports/dtm-sudan-focused-flash-alert-kordofan-region-7?close=true; FFMS-D-005687; FFMS-D-005630; FFMS-D-005678; FFMS-D-005674

[42] FFMS_0483; FFMS_0485; FFMS_0486; https://www.wfp.org/news/wfp-acting-executive-directors-press-conference-following-his-mission-sudan-remarks-delivered?.

[43] FFMS_0480; FFMS-D-00530; FFMS-D-005678.

[44] FFMS-D-005697; FFMS-D-005698; FFMS-D-005699; FFMS-D-005687; FFMS-D-005687; FFMS-D-005630; FFMS-D-005679; FFMS-D-005681.

diseases.[45] On 29 September, the United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs warned that water trucking at the Al Mina Al Bari displacement site, hosting more than 9,000 families, was at risk of interruption owing to rising fuel costs and funding shortages.[46]

42. Collecting water also exposed civilians to protection risks, particularly women and girls required to travel considerable distances to collect water, increasing their exposure to harassment and sexual violence. The insecurity surrounding access to water thus increased the risks associated with meeting an essential daily need[47].

43. Access to healthcare remained severely constrained by shortages of medicines, electricity, water and fuel, while insecurity and high transport costs impeded access to functioning facilities and referrals. These constraints posed particular risks to patients requiring emergency obstetric and neonatal care, treatment for serious injuries or continuous medical support, for whom delays or interruptions could be life-threatening.[48]

44. The deterioration of essential services coincided with the loss of livelihoods and household resources. Displacement deprived many families of access to agricultural land, livestock and income, while insecurity disrupted cultivation, trade and transport. Greater reliance on purchased food left households increasingly vulnerable to high prices and interruptions in supply.[49] In its alert of 12 October 2026, the Integrated Food Security Phase Classification warned that conflict, mass displacement, poor rainfall and restricted livelihood opportunities were worsening food insecurity and reducing harvest prospects across Greater Kordofan.[50]

45. Together, these interconnected pressures progressively eroded the civilian population's capacity to meet basic needs. Displacement increased demand for already strained services, while loss of income and rising costs restricted access to food, healthcare and other essentials, even where these remained available. These conditions have increased dependence on humanitarian assistance precisely as insecurity, insufficient funding and operational constraints have limited the capacity of humanitarian organisations to respond.[51] These pressures were further compounded by restrictions affecting humanitarian access and operations, examined below.

b) Restrictions on humanitarian space and civilian protection

46. Humanitarian operations across Sudan have been impeded by extensive administrative and operational restrictions imposed by bodies associated with the Sudanese Armed Forces and the Rapid Support Forces. Humanitarian activities have been hampered by prolonged delays in obtaining visas for international staff, travel permits and other authorisations, alongside multiple approval requirements governing personnel, supplies and field activities.[52] Competing registration requirements imposed by the warring parties in areas under their control, exposed organisations to the risk of losing permission to operate in one area for complying with requirements imposed in another. In and around El Obeid, these impediments,

[45] FFMS-D-005630: FFMS-D-005689; FFMS-D-005687.
[46] UN Secretary-General's Spokesperson's daily press briefing, 29 September 2026, https://press.un.org/en/2026/db260929.doc.htm?
[47] FFMS-D-005687; FFMS-D-00565630; FFMS-D-005630; FFMS-D-005681; FFMS-D-005678.
[48] FFMS-D-005672; FFMS-D-005679; FFMS-D-005687; FFMS-D-005674; FFMS-D-005676; FFMS-D-005689.
[49] FFMS-D-005697; FFMS-D-005698; FFMS-D-005699; FFMS-D-005682; FFMS-D-005678; FFMS-D-005674; FFMS-D-005676.
[50] FFMS_0484.
[51] FFMS_0482.
[52] FFMS-D-005708; FFMS-D-005696; FFMS-D-005693.

together with insecurity and drone attacks, constrained humanitarian access and operations.

47. Restrictions also extended to the conduct of humanitarian and protection work within areas where access had been authorised. During visits to displacement sites, security officials were reportedly present, hindering the ability to conduct independent needs assessments and safe, confidential engagement with affected communities. Civilians feared identification, detention or reprisals for communicating with humanitarian personnel or reporting violations.[53] Such fears may deter survivors of sexual violence, relatives of detained or missing persons and witnesses to alleged violations from disclosing violations and abuses or seeking assistance.[54]

48. The inability to interact freely with the civilian population may restrict opportunities for humanitarian actors to identify protection needs and arrange safe referrals. Restrictions on the ability to assess needs independently and deliver assistance without undue interference may reduce the effectiveness of access in practice, leaving critical protection needs unidentified and unmet. Under international humanitarian law, parties must allow and facilitate rapid and unimpeded passage of impartial humanitarian relief for civilians in need. While they retain their right of control, they must not withhold consent arbitrarily.

49. These restrictions were particularly consequential in El Obeid, where displacement, repeated attacks and damage to essential infrastructure had increased reliance on humanitarian assistance. Humanitarian actors reported that assistance remained concentrated in a limited number of official displacement sites, while other displacement locations, informal settlements and host communities received limited coverage[55]. Restrictions on movement and field assessments further reduced the ability of organisations to identify and reach populations in need, leaving critical humanitarian and protection needs unmet.

F. Shrinking civic space in El Obeid

50. As military operations intensified around El Obeid, civilians faced growing suspicion of affiliation or cooperation with the opposing party. Surveillance, intimidation and reprisals by security actors, operating in areas under the control of the Sudanese Armed Forces, increased.[56]

51. The mission received accounts indicating that the threat of arrest and reprisals increasingly constrained civic participation and the exercise of fundamental freedoms in El Obeid. Witnesses described an environment in which civilians increasingly feared that support for peace initiatives, criticism of authorities, engagement in humanitarian activities, perceived links to pro-democracy movements, participation in civic initiatives, or cooperation with efforts to document violations could expose individuals or their relatives to accusations of collaboration and to surveillance, threats, arbitrary detention, or other forms of retaliation. Victims stated that accusations of collaboration were frequently directed against individuals on the basis of their professional activities, ethnic or community identity, geographic location, social connections, or perceived political affiliation, rather than specific evidence of unlawful conduct.[57]

[53] FFMS-D-005690; FFMS-D-005676; FFMS-D-005674; FFMS-D-005640; FFMS-D-005640; FFMS-D-5696; FFMS-D-5693; FFMS-D-5708.

[54] FFMS-D-005674; FFMS-D-005640; FFMS-D-005690; FFMS-D-005696; FFMS-D-005696.

[55] FFMS-D-005708; FFMS-D-005696; FFMS-D-005693.

[56] FFMS-D-005687; FFMS-D-005698; FFMS-D-005699.

[57] FFMS-D-005687; FFMS-D-005682; FFMS-D-005698; FFMS-D-005699; FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005701; FFMS-D-005703.

52. Security cell personnel monitored political activity and identified individuals perceived as disloyal. Those associated with the December Revolution, civil society initiatives, labour activism, humanitarian work and anti-war advocacy, faced heightened risk of scrutiny. The mission received accounts of youth activists being taken to unofficial locations, questioned and threatened with arrest and detention for engagement in such activities. Others were warned they could be detained or face grave consequences unless they demonstrated support for the war effort.[58] These accounts indicate the use of security scrutiny and threats of detention to discourage activities ordinarily protected by the rights to freedom of expression, peaceful assembly and association.

53. Multiple witnesses reported that professionals, humanitarian workers, labour representatives, community leaders and individuals involved in civic initiatives had become increasingly reluctant to engage because of fear of accusations of supporting the opposing party to the conflict. Women working in markets, including tea sellers and informal food vendors, were subjected to accusations of affiliation with the Rapid Support Forces, which illustrates how suspicion extended into ordinary civilian livelihoods.[59]

54. In July and August 2026, several witnesses in El Obeid who had previously expressed willingness to provide information to the mission withdrew or stopped responding due to concerns about reprisals. Others feared surveillance and that engagement with human rights documentation initiatives could expose them or their family members to arrest, detention, or other forms of retaliation. Several stated that reports of arbitrary detention, prolonged incommunicado detention, torture and deaths in detention had generated widespread anxiety within communities and discouraged engagement with independent civic activities and accountability processes.[60]

55. Human rights defenders reported avoiding the documentation of drone attacks or photographing drone wreckage or damage because such activities could be interpreted as assisting Rapid Support Forces and expose them to accusations of collaboration and reprisals.[61] Some feared that documenting the location of artillery or drone strikes on social media could be regarded as assisting the Rapid Support Forces.[62] Others referred to arrests linked to online expression and threats against individuals who complained about abuses.[63]

56. Some witnesses reported deliberately limiting communications, avoiding public discussions of the conflict, restricting their movements or abandoning documentation activities because of concerns for their safety and that of their relatives.[64] Humanitarian actors similarly described concerns that their activities could be mischaracterized as support for one of the parties to the conflict. The wider risk is reflected in the mission's report on external support networks (A/HRC/63/23), which identified that survivors, witnesses, journalists, lawyers and human rights defenders faced intimidation and harassment, not only in El Obeid but throughout Sudan as well as outside Sudan, conducted by all parties, including for cooperating with the mission. These fears obstruct independent documentation of ongoing violations.

[58] FFMS-D-005698; FFMS-D-005699.
[59] FFMS-D-005687.
[60] FFMS-D-005698; FFMS-D-005699; FFMS-D-005700.
[61] FFMS-D-005630; FFMS-D-005699; FFMS-D-005677; FFMS-D-005678.
[62] FFMS-D-005677.
[63] FFMS-D-005687; FFMS-D-005701; FFMS-D-5676; FFMS-D-5673.
[64] FFMS-D-005698; FFMS-D-005699; FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005677; FFMS-D-005678; FFMS-D-005687.

G. Arbitrary detention as a mechanism of social control

57. Arbitrary detention in El Obeid is increasingly functioning as a broader mechanism of social and political control. Evidence collected by the mission indicates that detention and security screening targeted civilians on grounds extending beyond suspected participation in hostilities, removing individuals from public life and contributing to a wider climate of intimidation. The evidence demonstrates a pattern of arrests by El Obeid Security Cell personnel targeting individuals perceived as influential community figures, critics of the authorities, trade union representatives, professionals, academics and civilians from communities perceived as sympathetic to, or associated with the Rapid Support Forces, often on the basis of broadly framed national security allegations.[65]

58. Humanitarian actors and their relatives have also been subjected to arrests, threats and accusations of collaboration, reinforcing concerns that allegations of affiliation with the Rapid Support Forces are being used against a broad range of civilian actors engaged in professional, humanitarian and civic activities.

59. Credible information received by the mission demonstrates that allegations of collaboration with the Rapid Support Forces constituted one of the principal grounds for detention and prosecution among individuals held in the El Obeid Central Prison. Regional and ethnic origin, particularly links to Kordofan and Darfur, appear to particularly generate suspicions of loyalty to the Rapid Support Forces and their allies.[66] In one case documented by the mission, medical and teaching staff were arrested on suspicion of collaboration with the Rapid Support Forces. Interrogations reportedly focused extensively on tribal identity, alleged political loyalties and private communications. They reportedly received death threats, pressure to confess and demands that they sign statements they were not permitted to read. Although subsequently acquitted of the most serious charges, they remained in detention for several months.[67]

60. The mission also documented the detention of a person involved in trade union activities following public criticism of the authorities concerning workers' rights. The individual reported being held incommunicado by intelligence personnel, without access to legal counsel or family members, before transfer to El Obeid Central Prison. Detention reportedly continued for more than two months without effective judicial review. The individual was subsequently released following a protest against the detention and reported pressure from intelligence officials to abandon further trade union activities.[68]

a) Access to lawyers and family visits

61. Detainees reported prolonged detention without judicial review and denial of access to lawyers during the interrogation phase. Former detainees described serious due process concerns during arrest, investigation and detention. They described a pattern in which persons accused of collaboration with the Rapid Support Forces were first held and interrogated in Security Cell facilities, without access to lawyers, family members, or outside communication. According to these accounts, access to lawyers and family visits were generally permitted only after the investigative phase had concluded, charges had been brought and detainees had been transferred to prison.[69] In several cases, detainees were reportedly questioned only after weeks in custody. Detainees who were ultimately convicted of collaborating with the Rapid Support

[65] FFMS-D-005698; FFMS-D-005699; FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005701; FFMS-D-005703; FFMS-D-005682.
[66] FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005701; FFMS-D-005703.
[67] FFMS-D-005705.
[68] FFMS-D-005701.
[69] FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005701; FFMS-D-005703.

Forces risked receiving the death penalty. The El Obeid Central Prison has a special ward for death-row inmates.[70]

b) Conditions of detention

62. Detainees described severe overcrowding in both Security Cell facilities and El Obeid Central Prison.

63. Detainees at the Security Cell facilities often lacked sufficient space to sit or lie down. One former detainee described between 35 and 40 detainees confined in a cell within a Security Cell Facility measuring approximately 2.5 by 2 metres, and between nine and fourteen detainees held in a cell measuring approximately 1.5 by 3 metres, indicating an extreme lack of personal space, with significant implications for detainees' health and humane treatment.

64. Detainees held in custody in Security Cell facilities or police stations described inadequate sanitation and hygiene, restricted access to toilets and cells contaminated by human waste. The combination of overcrowding and inadequate sanitation exposed detainees to conditions presenting serious risks to health and dignity. In some police detention facilities, detainees had to urinate in bottles or buckets inside their cells. One account described approximately 200 detainees sharing a single toilet.

65. Overcrowding was also reported at El Obeid Central Prison. Multiple sources estimated that the prison held approximately 2,000 detainees and convicted prisoners, against a reported capacity of approximately 450.[71] Although these estimates require verification, the accounts consistently describe a a prison population substantially exceeding available accommodation.

66. Prison wards in the El Obeid Central Prison reportedly contained toilets within living and sleeping areas, producing persistent foul odours. Detainees also described poor ventilation, extreme heat, lack of electricity, and inadequate washing facilities. The reported lack of adequate ventilation and sanitation was particularly serious in heavily overcrowded wards.[72]

67. Food in police detention facilities, Security Cell facilities and the El Obeid Central Prison was described as inadequate and of poor quality. Several victims also reported problems with drinking water. Available water was reportedly saline and unsuitable for drinking.[73]

68. Detainees also described severely limited access to healthcare in police detention facilities, Security Cell facilities and the El Obeid Central Prison compounded by overcrowding, inadequate sanitation and limited access to safe drinking water. Health services were described as extremely limited. Those with chronic illnesses reported receiving only basic pain medication irrespective of their medical needs. One detainee with diabetes and high blood pressure stated that he was denied appropriate treatment throughout the period of detention.[74]

c) Torture, ill-treatment and deaths in custody

69. The mission received numerous accounts of physical and psychological abuse during detention, particularly in Security Cell facilities where persons accused of collaborating with the Rapid Support Forces were interrogated without effective

[70] FFMS-D-005700.
[71] FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005701; FFMS-D-005705.
[72] FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005701; FFMS-D-005705; FFMS-D-005711; FFMS-D-005712.
[73] FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005701; FFMS-D-005705; FFMS-D-005711; FFMS-D-005712.
[74] FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005701; FFMS-D-005705; FFMS-D-005711; FFMS-D-005712.

access to legal safeguards. The accounts indicate that the initial period of custody presented a heightened risk of torture and other forms of ill-treatment.[75]

70. Detainees described death threats, beatings, verbal abuse and coercive interrogations aimed at extracting confessions and obtaining cooperation. Detainees were frequently transferred to prison only after written confessions had been secured.[76] Security officials reportedly warned detainees that alleged collaborators with the Rapid Support Forces could be killed because of the conflict and state of emergency. Neither armed conflict nor a state of emergency permits torture or the killing of persons in custody. Such threats are particularly significant when made by personnel exercising direct control over detainees.

71. One former detainee described witnessing repeated physical assaults against other detainees, including slapping and beatings during interrogation. Another reported seeing young detainees accused of links with the Rapid Support Forces being beaten with hands, feet, whips and hoses by security personnel.

72. The mission received accounts of deaths and serious illness during detention in police custody facilities and Security Cell facilities. Death in custody was reported to the mission as occurring due to torture, inadequate healthcare and poor detention conditions.[77] One detainee reported that two fellow detainees died after illnesses, believed to be cholera, while held in police custody, attributing the deaths to inadequate sanitation and medical care. Other detainees were reportedly removed from the facility and their subsequent whereabouts were unknown.

d) Female detainees and prisoners

73. Women, including pregnant women, suspected of collaboration with the Rapid Support Forces were also held in Security Cell facilities before transfer to El Obeid Central Prison. Some women were reportedly detained together with young children, including infants, in facilities affected by severe overcrowding and inadequate sanitation.[78]

74. Women detained in El Obeid Central Prison reportedly lacked adequate access to essential hygiene supplies, including sanitary products and facilities necessary to maintain personal hygiene, compromising their ability to maintain menstrual hygiene and exposing them to conditions that further undermined their health and dignity.[79]

75. The mission also received credible allegations of sexual violence, harassment and coercion against women held in Security Cell facilities. Information collected points to serious and credible allegations of sexual and gender-based violence against women while detained in the Security Cell facilities. According to reliable independent sources, women, including some detained with infants, were subjected to sexual harassment, threats, humiliation and coercion by Security Cell personnel. Allegations included demands for sexual acts in exchange for release, preferential treatment or family visits.[80] These accounts raise serious concern regarding sexual violence and abuse of authority over women in detention. The full extent of these alleged abuses is yet to be revealed as access to survivors remains limited, including due to reported fears of reprisals.

76. Taken together, these accounts indicate that allegations of collaboration with the Rapid Support Forces were used to target civilians engaged in labour activism, civil society activities and criticism of the authorities, as well as those perceived as

[75] FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005701; FFMS-D-005703.
[76] FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005701; FFMS-D-005703.
[77] FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005701; FFMS-D-005705.
[78] FFMS-D-005711; FFMS-D-005712; FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005698; FFMS-D-005711; FFMS-D-005712.
[79] FFMS-D-005711; FFMS-D-005712; FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005705.
[80] FFMS-D-005711; FFMS-D-005712; FFMS-D-005700; FFMS-D-005705.

politically disloyal. Reports of prolonged detention without effective judicial oversight, coercive interrogation and threats against complainants suggest that detention and the threat of detention served to intimidate, foster self-censorship and discourage civic participation and public criticism of the authorities in El Obeid.

III. Attacks on human rights defenders throughout Sudan and beyond

77. Information received by the mission indicates that the dynamics documented in El Obeid form part of a broader pattern observed across Sudan and Sudan's borders. In its earlier report *Sudan: a war of atrocities* (A/HRC/60/22) and more recently, its oral update to the Human Rights Council in June 2026, the mission reported on arbitrary detention, torture and enforced disappearance and concluded that these had become increasingly prominent features of the conflict in Sudan.[81] The mission documented patterns of arbitrary detention and ill-treatment by both the Sudanese Armed Forces and the Rapid Support Forces targeting civilians perceived to be affiliated with or sympathetic to opposing parties, including journalists, human rights defenders, humanitarian workers, activists and community leaders.

78. The mission continues to receive reports that civilians travelling between territories controlled by opposing parties throughout Sudan, including from and to El Obeid, faced accusations of collaboration, and risks of detention, ill-treatment, enforced disappearance and other forms of reprisals. Such suspicions were reportedly based on place of residence, family connections, ethnic identity, or perceived political allegiance and could extend to communication with relatives living in territories controlled by opposing forces, engagement in humanitarian activities or contact with international organisations. Civilians were increasingly pressured to demonstrate allegiance to one of the parties to the conflict as a condition for their security and freedom. The mission will continue to investigate these reports and may address them in future reporting.

79. The mission is also concerned by indications that intimidation associated with the conflict extends beyond Sudan's borders. Information received by the mission indicates that Sudanese journalists, activists, human rights defenders and pro-democracy advocates residing abroad have increasingly been subjected to threats, harassment and intimidation linked to their public engagement on developments in Sudan.

80. The mission received reports from Sudanese civil society actors residing in neighbouring countries, including Chad, Kenya and Uganda, who described concerns regarding monitoring, threats and reprisals linked to their human rights work, documentation activities and advocacy concerning violations committed during the conflict. Several interlocutors reported modifying their public activities, restricting online engagement or avoiding participation in advocacy initiatives because of concerns for their own safety and for relatives remaining in Sudan.

81. The mission also reviewed information concerning an incident involving Sudanese human rights defenders in the United Kingdom. It received reports that a human rights advocate was assaulted while addressing a public event in the United Kingdom after publicly criticising abuses committed by all parties to the conflict. The mission also learned about additional concerns regarding threats and harassment directed at Sudanese rights advocates in the diaspora when engaged in advocacy concerning Sudan.

82. In October 2026, a prominent Sudanese writer and supporter of democratic transition residing outside Sudan was the subject of online content explicitly calling

[81] Https://www.ohchr.org/sites/default/files/documents/hrbodies/hrcouncil/ffm-sudan/20260615-oral-update-ffm-sudan-62nd-hrc-en.pdf.

for the person's killing because of their public criticism of the war and support for democratic governance. Civil society actors condemned the incident and expressed concern that such threats sought not only to intimidate the individual concerned but also to discourage broader participation in public debate among Sudanese communities living in exile.

83. While the mission continues to investigate individual incidents, the information currently available indicates that intimidation linked to the conflict increasingly affects Sudanese voices residing in Sudan and abroad. Such conduct raises concerns regarding transnational repression and may contribute to self-censorship among activists, journalists, human rights defenders and victims seeking to cooperate with accountability mechanisms.

IV. Factual and legal findings

a) Attacks against civilians

84. The Mission reiterates its findings concerning drone attacks in El Obeid, as set out in (A/HRC/63/23). The mission has reasonable grounds to believe that the Rapid Support Forces conducted drone strikes, in populated areas of El Obeid, resulting in multiple deaths and injuries, as documented in section II.C above. Repeated strikes affected residential neighbourhoods, educational facilities, locations where civilians had gathered or sought shelter, and civilian infrastructure, including fuel stations and electricity infrastructure. The manner in which drone strikes are taking place violates the obligations of the Rapid Support Forces to respect the principles of distinction, proportionality and precautions in attack. Such violations may amount to war crimes.

85. In deploying personnel and military equipment within or near civilian infrastructure and populated areas in El Obeid, the Sudanese Armed Forces appear to have failed to take all feasible precautions to protect civilians under their control against the effects of attacks. These deployments did not diminish the protection afforded to civilians under international humanitarian law or relieve the Rapid Support Forces of their independent obligations to respect the principles of distinction, proportionality and precautions in attack. The documented unlawful attacks indicate failures by the Rapid Support Forces to respect these principles.

b) Intimidation, arbitrary arrest and detention

86. The information gathered by the mission also indicates that surveillance, threats, arbitrary arrests, detention, ill-treatment, and other forms of intimidation, including as acts of reprisals, continue to affect civilians in El Obeid.

87. The mission finds that the Sudanese Armed Forces, affiliated security actors and allied forces targeted civilians based on their actual or perceived affiliation with the Rapid Support Forces, or for their engagement in accountability processes, with civilians kept under surveillance, restricting freedom of movement. Civilians, including children, were arbitrarily arrested and detained in violation of fundamental guarantees under international human rights law and international humanitarian law, including their right to liberty and security, and to due process. In most documented cases, detainees were not informed of the reason of their arrest, or of the charges against them, and were denied prompt judicial review before competent legal authorities.

88. In limited circumstances where reasons for arrest were given, they were based on broadly framed national security allegations. In several instances individuals were held in unofficial detention locations including Security Cell facilities for prolonged periods and denied legal counsel before being transferred to the El Obeid Central Prison. They were held in inhumane conditions including severely overcrowded cells, where they lacked sufficient food, water, hygiene and medical care. They were also subjected to ill-treatment and torture including verbal threats, tribal insults, and

physical assaults including beatings and slaps, during interrogations whose purpose was aimed at eliciting confessions. The mission also received credible allegations that female detainees and prisoners were subjected to sexual violence, sexual harassment and at times sexual exploitation by Security Cell personnel. These practices raise serious concerns regarding arbitrary and incommunicado detention, the absence of effective judicial oversight and the ability of detainees to challenge the lawfulness of their detention.

89. The mission finds that the detention practices applied by the Sudanese Armed Forces in El Obeid amount to serious violations of international humanitarian law, including violence to life and person and outrages upon dignity, as well as violations of international human rights law, including the prohibition of torture and other cruel, inhuman or degrading treatment or punishment, and the right to life, liberty, security of person, health and adequate food. Such conduct may amount to war crimes, particularly cruel treatment, torture, and outrages upon personal dignity.

90. The mission continues to receive reports of attacks on human rights defenders perpetrated by the parties to the conflict and their allies. It finds that the parties to the conflict violate their obligations to protect human rights defenders, including, lawyers, journalists, peace activities, humanitarian and emergency respondents, when they order such attacks or fail to investigate and prosecute them.

IV. Conclusion and Recommendations

91. The mission finds that the protection of civilians in and around El Obeid remains a matter of serious concern. Although the complete siege and large-scale ground attack feared when the initial alarm was raised in July 2026 did not materialise during the reporting period, the situation in and around El Obeid remains grave, with violations of international human rights law and humanitarian law continuing unabated.

92. The Rapid Support Forces continue their campaign of long-range drone attacks, resulting in civilian casualties and destruction of civilian infrastructure, compounding existing displacement pressures. Though the Sudanese Armed Forces have reopened the Khartoum–El Obeid corridor, the use of the route remains dangerous for the civilian population due to sustained drone attacks by the Rapid Support Forces. These attacks violate the obligations of the Rapid Support Forces to respect the principles of distinction, proportionality and precautions in attack and may amount to war crimes.

93. The Sudanese Armed Forces' deployment of personnel and military equipment in residential neighbourhoods and near markets exposes civilians to heightened risks and persistent fear of attack, particularly where insecurity, repeated displacement and depleted resources leave them with limited means to seek shelter or evacuate. At the same time affiliated security actors intensify surveillance and target those engaged in peace, humanitarian and human rights work. The mission finds that reprisals, including arbitrary arrest and detention, ill-treatment and torture, are increasing, further shrinking civic space and deterring people from reporting violations or engaging with accountability efforts.

94. The shrinking of civic space undermines the ability of the people of Sudan to discuss pathways out of the current humanitarian, human rights and protection crisis, the consequences of which will affect them for generations. No credible Sudanese dialogue can take place under such circumstances.

95. The mission therefore recommends urgent action on the following:

a) **Protection of civilians**. The Sudanese Armed Forces and the Rapid Support Forces must silence the weapons, cease hostilities, comply with their obligations under international law and refrain from directing attacks, including drone strikes, against civilians and other protected persons,

including medical personnel, and against civilian objects, including those indispensable to the survival of civilians; they must protect displaced communities and displacement sites and allow safe routes for civilians out of active conflict zones. To enhance civilian protection, the Security Council should enforce and expand the arms embargo to cover the whole of Sudan, and third States should stop material support to the parties.

b) **Humanitarian assistance**. The warring parties must ensure compliance with international humanitarian law by allowing and facilitating rapid and unimpeded passage for humanitarian assistance in and around El Obeid, and elsewhere in Sudan, including through the removal of arbitrary administrative restrictions and an end to undue interference with humanitarian activities.

c) **Immediate end to intimidation, arbitrary arrests and detention**, and protection of lawyers, human rights defenders, humanitarian workers, journalists and civil society actors, and guarantees of their rights to freedom of expression, peaceful assembly and association. The parties must agree to and facilitate access by independent monitoring bodies to places of detention, including conducting confidential interviews with detainees.

d) **Prioritization of accountability processes**. Address impunity, ensure accountability and provide justice to victims including through a specialized independent judicial mechanism in the form of a specialized court for the Sudan working in tandem with the International Criminal Court, alongside a comprehensive transitional justice system, strengthened rule of law and due process guarantees in domestic legal processes. Co-operate with the International Criminal Court, support documentation processes, and ensure access to Sudan by regional and international accountability mechanisms.

e) **Protection and expansion of civic space.** All parties must protect and expand civic space as an essential condition for a genuine, inclusive Sudanese dialogue in which Sudanese people can participate freely, safely and meaningfully.